YOUR PROPERTY GUIDE

The Complete Guide to *Selling* Your Property in Australia

2026 Edition

What it really costs, how agents really work, and how to run a sale on your terms. Ten chapters of plain-English advice for every state and territory.

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FREE · 10 CHAPTERS

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Is now the right time to sell?

The honest answer is that nobody picks the top of the market, including the people paid to talk about it. What you can do is read the conditions in front of you.

Every year, thousands of Australians delay a sale waiting for a better market, and thousands more rush one because a neighbour got a big number. Both groups are usually reacting to headlines rather than data. The good news is that the data you need is free, local, and takes about an hour to read properly.

Read your suburb, not the nation

National price indexes are close to useless for an individual sale. Your market is your suburb, your property type, and your price bracket. A three-bedroom house in a family suburb and a one-bedroom unit two streets away can be moving in opposite directions at the same time.

Four numbers tell you most of what you need to know:

- **Days on market.** How long comparable properties are taking to sell. Under 30 days in most capitals suggests a seller's market. Past 60, buyers are in charge.
- **Auction clearance rates** (if you're in an auction city). Sustained clearance above roughly 65 per cent generally favours sellers. Below 55 per cent, campaigns are stalling.
- **Total listings.** If the number of comparable homes for sale in your suburb is rising month on month, you have more competition and less pricing power.
- **Vendor discounting.** The average gap between first asking price and final sale price. A widening gap means sellers are overreaching.

You can pull all four from the big portals' suburb profile pages, your state's valuer-general data, or simply by watching what sells near you for six weeks. If an agent quotes these numbers without being asked, that's a point in their favour.

60 days

PAST THIS MANY DAYS ON MARKET, BUYERS ARE IN CHARGE

Seasonality: spring is crowded for a reason

Australian listings peak in spring. September to November typically brings the year's biggest wave of new stock, with a second, smaller surge in late February and March once everyone is back from holidays. Winter and the December-January stretch are the quiet months.

Spring's reputation is partly self-fulfilling: gardens look better, buyers are active, and everyone has been told spring is the time to sell. The catch is that everyone else got the same memo. A well-presented home in August or early February often faces half the competition it would in October, in front of buyers who have been starved of stock for months.

The practical rule: sell when your property shows well and your local competition is thin, not when the calendar says so. A north-facing living room photographs beautifully in winter light. A jacaranda-lined street earns its keep in November. Work with what you have.

Sell first, or buy first?

If you're selling to buy again, this is the bigger decision than timing the market, because you're effectively trading in the same market you're buying in. If prices move, they move on both sides of your ledger.

Selling first gives you a known budget, a stronger negotiating position as a cash-ready buyer, and no risk of carrying two mortgages. The cost is uncertainty about where you'll live: you may need to rent, store furniture, or negotiate a long settlement or leaseback. In a rising market you can also find your sale proceeds buying less by the time you purchase.

Buying first means you move once and you know exactly where you're going. The risk is the other way: if your sale takes longer or lands lower than expected, you're funding two properties and negotiating your sale under time pressure, which buyers and their agents can smell. In a falling or slow market, buying first is the more dangerous order of operations.

A rough rule: in a hot market with thin stock, buying first is more defensible because your own sale is the easy part. In a soft market, sell first and rent if you must. Paying three months' rent is cheaper than knocking $40,000 off your price because settlement is looming.

> “ *Paying three months' rent is cheaper than knocking $40,000 off your price because settlement is looming.*

Bridging finance, briefly. A bridging loan covers the gap when you buy before you sell. The lender takes security over both properties, charges interest (often capitalised, meaning it compounds onto the loan) on the combined “peak debt”, and typically expects the old property sold within 6 to 12 months. It works, but it is not cheap, and the clock pressure it creates is exactly the pressure that produces discounted sales. Get the numbers modelled by a broker before you rely on it, and treat it as a backstop rather than a plan.

WATCH FOR

Agents who tell you the market is about to take off, every season, every year. Listing volume is how agencies eat. An agent’s incentive is for you to list soon and sell fast, which overlaps with your interests but is not identical to them. Trust the suburb data over the pep talk.

02

What your property is really worth

Three different people will give you three different numbers, and at least one of them has an incentive to be wrong. Here's how to find the real one.

Appraisal, valuation, estimate: not the same thing

An agent appraisal is a free market opinion from someone who wants your listing. It's usually informed by genuine local knowledge, but it is a sales document, not a neutral assessment. It carries no legal weight.

A bank valuation is a formal assessment by an independent certified valuer, ordered by a lender to protect the lender. Valuers are deliberately conservative because their job is to estimate what the bank would recover in a forced sale. Bank valuations commonly land 5 to 10 per cent below what a well-run campaign achieves. If a buyer's bank valuation comes in low, their loan can shrink, which is why "subject to finance" offers sometimes fall over even when the buyer is keen.

> **5 to 10%**
> HOW FAR BANK VALUATIONS COMMONLY LAND BELOW A WELL-RUN CAMPAIGN

Online estimates (the automated numbers on the major portals and bank apps) are statistical models fed by past sales data. For a standard house in a suburb with plenty of recent sales, they can be within a few per cent. For renovated, unusual, rural or recently quiet markets, they can miss by 10 to 20 per cent in either direction. Most platforms publish a confidence band with the number. Read it. A "$910,000 estimate" with a band of $780,000 to $1,040,000 is telling you, politely, that it doesn't know.

The order of reliability for an owner-occupier sale, from least to most useful: online estimate, bank valuation, a well-evidenced agent appraisal, and finally the only number that actually matters, which is what a buyer signs for.

How agents actually build a price

A competent agent prices your home with a comparative market analysis: recent *sold* prices (not asking prices) for genuinely comparable properties, ideally within about a kilometre and the last three to six months, adjusted for land size, condition, parking, aspect and street. They'll weigh current competition (what a buyer with your budget can buy instead this weekend) and buyer depth at your price point.

Ask every appraising agent to show you the comparables behind their number. The quality of that evidence is the single best test of the appraisal. Three settled sales of similar homes within a kilometre beats any amount of confidence at your kitchen table.

The two traps: underquoting and overquoting

Underquoting is advertising or quoting a price below the agent's genuine estimate to pull a bigger crowd, then letting competition push the price up. It mostly burns buyers, but it can hurt you too: a campaign anchored too low can stall at the anchor if competition doesn't materialise. NSW and Victoria both have specific underquoting laws. In NSW, the advertised price can't be below the agent's written estimate in your agency agreement. In Victoria, agents must publish a Statement of Information with an indicative selling price supported by three comparable sales. If an agent's quoting strategy makes you uncomfortable, that discomfort is data.

Overquoting runs the other way and is aimed squarely at you. An agent "buys the listing" by appraising high, knowing you'll pick the biggest number. Then comes **conditioning**: weeks of carefully relayed "buyer feedback" that the market thinks it's overpriced, until you agree to a reduction down to what the agent privately believed all along. You've lost four weeks, your listing has gone stale, and the agent still collects commission. Conditioning is the most common and least discussed cost of choosing an agent on appraisal price alone.

> **WATCH FOR**
>
> An appraisal that is more than about 10 per cent above the others, delivered with thin or cherry-picked comparables. Ask: "If you're so confident in this price, will you accept a shorter agency agreement, or tie part of your commission to achieving it?" Watch how fast the confidence recalibrates.

Sanity-check the number yourself

Before any agent walks through your door, spend an evening building your own view:

1. Pull every settled sale of a comparable property (same suburb, similar beds, baths, parking and land) from the past six months. Portal "sold" filters and state government sales data both work.
2. Throw out the outliers: the un-renovated deceased estate, the architect rebuild, the main-road block.
3. Adjust the survivors roughly for condition and land. Renovated kitchen and bathrooms might be worth 3 to 7 per cent in most suburbs; a busy road can cost 5 to 10.

4. Note the original asking price against the final sale price for each. That gap is your suburb's reality check.
5. Land on a range, not a number. If your range is $820,000 to $870,000 and an agent says $950,000, someone needs to show their working.

You will not be as accurate as a good local agent. You don't need to be. You need to be accurate enough to recognise flattery when it's holding a clipboard.

> *You need to be accurate enough to recognise flattery when it's holding a clipboard.*

03

The real cost of selling

Most sellers budget for commission and forget the rest. On a typical sale the "rest" runs to five figures. Here is every line item.

Agent commission

Commission is the big one, and it is entirely negotiable. There are no set rates anywhere in Australia. As a rule, commission runs lower where prices are high and competition between agencies is fierce (inner Sydney and Melbourne) and higher where prices are lower or markets are thin (regional and remote areas). The figures below are typical ranges as at mid-2026; your suburb will have its own going rate, which any agent will tell you if asked directly.

STATE / TERRITORY	TYPICAL COMMISSION RANGE	NOTES
NSW	1.8% - 2.5% (Sydney) 2.5% - 3.5% (regional)	Among the lowest metro rates in the country
Victoria	1.6% - 2.5% (Melbourne) 2.5% - 3.5% (regional)	Heavy agency competition keeps Melbourne rates down
Queensland	2.0% - 3.0% (SEQ) 2.5% - 3.5% (regional)	The old capped rate is long gone; everything is negotiable
Western Australia	2.2% - 3.25%	Perth averages sit higher than Sydney or Melbourne
South Australia	1.9% - 2.75%	Adelaide rates are among the sharpest in the country
Tasmania	2.5% - 3.25%	Smaller market, less discounting

STATE / TERRITORY	TYPICAL COMMISSION RANGE	NOTES
ACT	2.0% - 3.0%	Published averages vary widely by source; get three quotes
Northern Territory	2.5% - 4.0%	Darwin averages around 2.5%; remote areas higher

Always confirm whether a quoted rate **includes GST**. A “2.5 per cent” that turns out to be 2.75 per cent including GST is a $2,125 difference on an $850,000 sale. Get it in writing as a GST-inclusive figure. Some agents offer tiered structures (a base rate plus a higher percentage above an agreed threshold), which can align incentives well if the threshold is set honestly. More on negotiating in Chapter 5.

Marketing: $2,000 to $10,000

Marketing is almost always paid by you, on top of commission, and usually upfront or at settlement regardless of whether the property sells. A typical metro campaign:

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Portal listing (realestate.com.au and/or Domain, premium tier)	$1,500 - $5,000+
Professional photography (day, plus twilight shots)	$300 - $800
Floorplan	$150 - $350
Video walkthrough or drone	$500 - $1,500
Copywriting	$150 - $400
Signboard (photo board)	$150 - $450
Print, brochures, social media boosts	$200 - $1,000
Auctioneer (if auctioning)	$400 - $1,000

Portal pricing depends on your suburb’s median price, which is why the same ad costs three times as much in Mosman as in Maryborough. Chapter 7 covers which of these items actually move the needle.

Everything else

- **Conveyancing or solicitor fees: $800 to $2,500.** Covers contract preparation, state disclosure documents, and settlement. Complex sales (deceased estates, subdivisions, disputes) sit at the top end or above it.
- **Styling and staging.** A consultation using your own furniture: $200 to $500. Partial staging: $1,500 to $4,000. Full furniture hire for a vacant home: $2,000 to $8,000+ for a four-to-six-week campaign.

Chapter 4 covers when it pays.

- **Repairs and presentation.** Painting, garden tidy, minor trades. Budget $1,000 to $5,000 for a lived-in home; many sellers spend more, not always wisely.
- **Lender discharge fees.** If you have a mortgage, your lender charges a discharge administration fee, typically $150 to $600, plus a state government fee to register the discharge of mortgage, roughly $100 to $250 depending on the state. If you're on a fixed rate, ask about break costs before you list; on a large fixed loan these can run to thousands.
- **Council and water rate adjustments** are settled at settlement and are usually small, but they're on the statement.

Capital gains tax, in plain English

If the property has been **your main residence for the whole time you've owned it**, and you haven't used it to produce income, you generally pay no CGT at all. That covers most owner-occupier sales. (One quirk: the exemption generally applies from when you move in, so a long gap between buying and occupying can create a partial liability.)

If it's an **investment property**, the gain (sale price minus your "cost base", which includes the purchase price, stamp duty, buying and selling costs, and capital improvements) is added to your taxable income in the year you sign the contract. Two things soften it:

- **The 50 per cent discount.** Individuals who have held the property for more than 12 months pay tax on only half the gain.
- **The six-year rule.** If the property was your main residence before you rented it out, you can generally still treat it as your main residence for up to six years of absence, provided you're not claiming another property as your main residence at the same time.

Two traps. First, CGT is triggered by the **contract date**, not settlement, which matters if you exchange in late June. Second, if you've lived in it part of the time and rented it part of the time, the exemption is apportioned, and the sums get fiddly. For anything beyond a straightforward whole-period main residence, spend a few hundred dollars on an accountant before you list. It is the highest-return professional fee in this entire guide.

Worked example: an $850,000 sale

Owner-occupied house in suburban Brisbane, sold by private treaty with a mid-range campaign and partial staging:

COST ITEM	AMOUNT
Agent commission at 2.5% incl. GST	$21,250
Marketing campaign (portal premium, photos, floorplan, board, copy)	$4,300
Conveyancing, including disclosure documents	$1,400

COST ITEM	AMOUNT
Partial staging, four weeks	$2,800
Repairs, paint touch-ups, garden	$2,600
Lender discharge fee plus registration	$550
Total cost of sale	**$32,900**

$32,900

THE FULL COST OF SELLING IN THE WORKED $850,000 EXAMPLE

That's about 3.9 per cent of the sale price, with no CGT because it's a main residence. The same property as an investment held nine years with a $300,000 gross gain could add a tax bill in the tens of thousands depending on the owner's income, which is why investors should price the tax before they price the campaign.

04

Preparing your property

Buyers decide in the first 30 seconds and spend the rest of the inspection confirming the decision. Spend your money where those 30 seconds happen.

High-return fixes

The work that reliably returns more than it costs is cosmetic, fast and boring:

- **Paint.** Fresh neutral walls are the cheapest transformation in real estate. A few thousand dollars of painting routinely adds multiples of that in perceived value, because buyers mentally price “needs painting” at triple the actual quote.
- **Street appeal.** The front fence, letterbox, lawn edges, a pressure-washed driveway and a $60 pot by the door. Buyers form their offer range on the footpath.
- **Light.** Clean every window, lift wattage, replace dated fittings, trim whatever’s blocking the living-room sun. Photographers and buyers both buy light.
- **Minor kitchen and bathroom refreshes.** New tapware, handles, regrouted tiles, a resurfaced benchtop. The aim is “nothing to do here”, not “newly renovated”.
- **Fix the small broken things.** Dripping taps, sticky doors, cracked switch plates, the gate that doesn’t latch. Each one whispers “what else haven’t they maintained?”

> “ *Buyers form their offer range on the footpath.*

Money pits

Big renovations done specifically for sale rarely pay. A $60,000 kitchen might add $40,000 to the price; the buyer would rather have chosen their own benchtop. Pools, full bathroom gut-jobs, extensions and structural work almost never recover their cost on a pre-sale timeline, and they delay your campaign by months. The rule: renovate to live, present to sell. If a room is genuinely dated, it is usually cheaper to price it honestly than to rebuild it for a stranger's taste.

$40,000

WHAT A $60,000 PRE-SALE KITCHEN MIGHT ADD TO THE PRICE

Decluttering is free and worth more than most renovations

Half-empty cupboards read as ample storage. Full ones read as "this house is too small", even to buyers with twice your stuff. Clear benchtops, thin out furniture so rooms breathe, take down the family photo wall (buyers need to imagine their own life in the frame), and hire a storage unit for a month if you must. It costs $150 to $400 and is the best presentation spend per dollar available.

When staging pays

Professional styling earns its keep most clearly in three situations: vacant properties (empty rooms photograph small and echo at opens), tired or dated interiors where good furniture redirects attention, and competitive metro markets above roughly the suburb median, where buyers compare your listing photos against a feed of styled ones. Industry claims about staging adding 5 to 10 per cent to sale prices are vendor-funded and best taken with salt, but the asymmetry is real: on a $900,000 home, staging needs to add less than half a per cent to break even. For a well-furnished, well-kept home, a consultation plus partial staging usually captures most of the benefit at a third of the cost.

Photography timing

Book photography **after** every other job is finished, not before the last trades visit. Brief the photographer on your property's best hour: north-facing living areas mid-morning, west-facing gardens late afternoon, and a twilight shoot if the facade or view earns it. If you're planning a spring campaign, consider shooting the garden at its peak even if you list weeks later. And shoot before the signboard goes up; nothing dates a "fresh" listing like its own For Sale sign in the hero photo.

The pre-sale building and pest inspection

Commissioning your own building and pest report before listing ($400 to $800 combined) is one of the genuinely contested calls in selling.

The case for: no surprises mid-campaign. You learn about the termite damage or the dodgy subfloor while you can still fix it cheaply or price it calmly, rather than at the negotiating table where every defect costs triple. In the ACT, a building and pest report is part of the mandatory pre-listing contract pack anyway, and some sellers elsewhere offer their report to buyers to keep momentum up and conditions out of contracts.

The case against: the cost, and the knowledge itself. Once you know about a defect, you cannot honestly characterise the property as though you don't, and in some states (notably Queensland under its disclosure regime, discussed in Chapter 9) your formal disclosure obligations are growing. Serious buyers will commission their own report regardless and may not trust yours.

The sensible middle: if your home is older than 30 years, has had past termite activity in the area, or you simply don't know its condition, get the report. Walking into a negotiation with less information than the other side is how sellers lose five figures in an afternoon.

> **WATCH FOR**
>
> Trades and stylists recommended exclusively by your agent without alternatives. Most agent referrals are honest, and some agencies disclose referral fees, but get one outside quote for any job over $1,000. If the agent's painter is 40 per cent dearer, you've learned something about the rest of the advice.

05

Choosing your agent

The most expensive mistake in selling isn't the commission rate. It's hiring the agent with the best suit and the biggest appraisal.

What actually predicts a good agent

Ignore the billboard, the awards (mostly bought or self-awarded) and the appraisal number (Chapter 2 explained why the biggest one is often a trap). Three things predict results:

- **Recent comparable sales.** Not sales generally: sales of properties like yours, near yours, in the last six months. An agent who sold three similar homes within a kilometre has a live buyer database for your exact property. That is worth more than any marketing plan.
- **Days on market and discounting.** How fast do their listings sell against the suburb average, and how far below the first advertised price? Both numbers are visible on the portals and agent comparison sites if you look at their past listings, not their brochure.
- **Vendor reviews with specifics.** "Great communicator" is filler. "Called every Monday with written feedback from every group through" is signal. Ask for two recent vendors you can actually phone. Good agents hand these over without flinching.

Interview at least three agents. Not to triangulate the price (though it helps), but because agents behave differently when they know they're in a contest. You'll also hear three marketing plans and quickly learn which parts are boilerplate.

The 10 questions to ask every agent

01 **What have you personally sold within a kilometre of here in the past six months, and for how much?**
Names and numbers, not “we’re very active in the area”.

02 **What’s your average days on market, and how does it compare with this suburb’s average?**

03 **What’s your average discount from first advertised price to sale price?**
This exposes habitual overquoters in one question.

04 **Who will actually attend my open homes and take buyer calls: you, or someone I haven’t met?**
Big-name agents often delegate everything after the listing is signed.

05 **Walk me through the marketing plan line by line. What does each item cost, and who pays if the property doesn’t sell?**

06 **What is your commission including GST, and exactly what triggers it?**

07 **How long is your agency agreement, and how do I exit if it isn’t working?**

08 **What price range will you put in writing on the agency agreement, and which three comparable sales support it?**

09 **How many other listings are you running right now?**
Fifteen listings means your campaign gets a fifteenth of someone’s week.

10 **Can I speak to your last two vendors, including one whose sale was difficult?**

Negotiating the commission

Commission is negotiable everywhere in Australia, and agents expect the conversation. Some tactics that work:

- **Use the contest.** “I have three appraisals; you’re the agent I’d prefer, but your rate is the highest” is honest and effective.
- **Consider a tiered rate.** For example 2 per cent up to an agreed realistic threshold, then 8 to 10 per cent of every dollar above it. It rewards the result you actually want. The threshold must come from comparable-sale evidence, not the agent’s appraisal, or you’ve just paid a bonus for overquoting.
- **Negotiate marketing too.** Agencies often have portal volume deals; ask what the agency contributes, and strip items you don’t need (Chapter 7).
- **Don’t grind to zero.** The cheapest agent’s discount is roughly 0.5 per cent. A better negotiator gets you 2 or 3 per cent more on price. Hire the negotiator; you’re about to watch them work against buyers, and the audition is how they defended their own fee.

Agency agreements: what you're signing

The agreement is a binding contract. The three common types:

- **Exclusive agency:** one agent, who is paid commission no matter who finds the buyer, including you. Standard for most residential sales; agents work hardest with protection.
- **Sole agency:** one agent, but if you genuinely find the buyer yourself, no commission. Worth requesting if you have a plausible private buyer.
- **General / open listing:** multiple agents, commission to whoever sells. Sounds competitive; in practice nobody invests in the campaign. Best reserved for hard-to-sell stock or unhurried sellers.

State rules worth knowing before you sign:

- **NSW:** residential agency agreements carry a cooling-off period of one business day (ending 5pm the next business day or Saturday), and it can't be waived for sales agreements. There's no statutory cap on the term, so set one: 8 to 12 weeks is reasonable, with the agreement converting to open or ending after that.
- **Victoria:** no cooling-off on a sale authority, so read before signing, not after. Exclusive authority periods are negotiable; 60 to 90 days is common. Check the rebate disclosure section: agents must disclose rebates they receive (for example from advertisers).
- **Queensland:** appointments use the prescribed Form 6. A sole or exclusive agency is capped at **90 days** for residential sales; you can reappoint, but only within the last 14 days of the current term, for further terms of up to 90 days. Open listings have no time limit.
- **South Australia:** residential sales agency agreements are capped at 90 days, renewable.
- **WA, Tasmania, NT, ACT:** no general statutory cooling-off on agency agreements, and term caps vary or don't exist, so negotiate the term and exit clause yourself. Anywhere in Australia, an agent who insists on more than 90 days exclusive for a standard home is protecting themselves, not you.

> # 90 days
> THE LONGEST EXCLUSIVE AGENCY TERM WORTH SIGNING ON A STANDARD HOME

Finally, read the commission trigger clause. You can owe commission if a buyer the agent introduced purchases after the agreement ends. That's fair protection against being cut out, but check the tail period (60 to 90 days is reasonable; open-ended is not) and that "introduced" is defined.

06

Auction, private treaty or off-market

Each method has a natural habitat. The mistake is letting an agent pick the one that suits their business rather than your property.

Auction

How it works: a set campaign (usually four weeks), no advertised price or a guide only, public competition on the day, and an unconditional contract signed on the fall of the hammer with no cooling-off for the buyer in any state.

The case for: auctions create a deadline and visible competition, which is the best price-discovery mechanism ever devised for scarce assets. When two emotionally invested bidders want the same house, the result can exceed any private negotiation. The unconditional contract removes finance and inspection risk at a stroke. And even a passed-in auction flushes out the genuine buyers for the negotiation that follows.

The case against: auctions need a crowd. With one bidder or none, a public pass-in stamps a “failed” flag on your campaign that follows it around. Auction campaigns also cost more (auctioneer plus typically heavier advertising), and some buyers, especially finance-dependent ones, simply won’t bid because they can’t go unconditional. In a thin market, an auction is an expensive way to discover there’s no competition.

Where auctions actually work: Sydney, Melbourne and Canberra have deep auction cultures, with weekly clearance rates above 60 per cent in normal conditions. Brisbane and Adelaide use auctions selectively, mostly for inner suburbs and prestige stock, and the share has been growing. Perth, Hobart and Darwin remain overwhelmingly private-treaty markets. Within auction cities, auctions favour inner and middle-ring suburbs, properties that are scarce or hard to price (character homes, development sites, anything with a view), and price brackets where buyer depth is strong. A standard outer-suburban house in a private-treaty city gains little from an auction beyond the agent’s theatre.

Reserve strategy: set the reserve the week of the auction, not the day you sign the agency agreement, and set it from campaign evidence: who’s requested contracts, what the buyer feedback bands say, what’s sold during your campaign. A reserve at the bottom of your genuine acceptable range lets the auction run; momentum stalls when the auctioneer has to halt and confer. Know the vendor-bid rules in your state (vendor bids must be announced), and decide your pass-in plan in advance: the highest bidder at a pass-in usually gets first right to negotiate, so brief your agent on your real floor before the day.

Private treaty

How it works: you list at an advertised price (or range), buyers make offers, you negotiate. Around eight in ten Australian sales happen this way.

> **8 in 10**
>
> AUSTRALIAN SALES THAT HAPPEN BY PRIVATE TREATY

The case for: control and reach. You can negotiate terms as well as price, accept conditional offers from the biggest possible buyer pool, take your time, and quietly adjust strategy without a public verdict. Costs are lower and the process suits every market, hot or cold.

The case against: no deadline means buyers can stall, and the first advertised price does most of the work; get it wrong and you'll be cutting it publicly three weeks later (Chapter 7's first-two-weeks rule). Buyers also get cooling-off periods in most states, so a "sold" sticker can come unstuck.

Off-market

An off-market sale skips public advertising: the agent shops your property to their buyer database. The pitch is privacy, no campaign costs and a fast result. The reality check: price discovery needs exposure, and an off-market sale by definition has the least. You're selling into one agent's contact list, and the buyer knows there's no visible competition. Genuine off-market premiums exist but are rare; quiet discounts are common. Off-market suits sellers who value privacy or speed over the last dollar, genuinely unique properties with a known shortlist of buyers, and as a pre-campaign test run ("we'll quietly offer it for two weeks before launch"). If an agent leads with an off-market buyer who is ready to pay strong money right now, ask the obvious question: strong compared with what? Without a campaign, neither of you knows.

> *Without a campaign, neither of you knows.*

WATCH FOR

Method-of-sale advice that conveniently matches the agency's habits. Some offices auction everything because auctions build the agent's profile; others avoid them because they can't run one. Ask what percentage of the agency's last 20 sales used each method, and how that compares with the suburb. The answer tells you whether the recommendation is about your house or their playbook.

07

Marketing that sells

Most marketing budgets contain three items that sell houses and five that sell agents. Learn to tell them apart.

The portals: where the buyers actually are

In Australia, property marketing means realestate.com.au first, Domain second, everything else a distant third. Almost every active buyer has saved searches on at least one portal, so your real marketing decision is which **listing tier** to buy.

Both portals sell tiered visibility. On realestate.com.au, the top tiers (the "Premiere"-style products) put your listing larger, higher in search results and with more photos, and refresh its position; standard listings sit lower and sink as new stock arrives. Domain's tiers work the same way. Pricing is dynamic and suburb-based: a top-tier listing can cost $1,000 to $2,000 in a cheaper regional market and $3,000 to $5,000 or more in expensive metro suburbs.

Is the top tier worth it? In a competitive suburb with dozens of active listings, usually yes: visibility decays fast and the premium is small against the price of going stale. In a tightly held suburb where anything listed gets seen, a mid-tier on the main portal plus a standard Domain listing often performs identically. What's rarely worth it: print advertising (except in some regional markets and the prestige bracket, where it still functions), and branded extras that promote the agency more than the address.

The assets that do the selling

- **Photography.** The hero shot decides whether a buyer taps your listing at all. Pay for a professional, shoot at the property's best hour, and lead with the strongest image, which is usually the facade or the main living space, not the bathroom. Eight to twelve excellent photos beat twenty-five mediocre ones.
- **Floorplan.** Arguably the highest-value $250 in the whole campaign. Buyers consistently rank floorplans among the first things they look for, and serious buyers filter out listings without one. Non-negotiable.

- **Copy.** Specifics sell: north-facing rear, 600 metres to the station, rewired 2023, 580 square metres. Adjective soup (“stunning”, “boasting”, “oozing charm”) is white noise buyers learned to skim years ago. Mention the school catchment by name if it matters; it often matters more than the kitchen.
- **Video and drone.** Worth it for properties where land, position or flow is the story (acreage, waterfront, view corridors, big blocks). For a standard suburban house, a good photo set and floorplan do the job, and the video budget is better spent on the portal tier.

> **$250**
>
> ARGUABLY THE HIGHEST-VALUE MARKETING SPEND: THE FLOORPLAN

Open homes versus private inspections

Open homes are efficient: every interested buyer through in 30 minutes, and a crowded open creates useful competitive anxiety (“who were all those people?”). Private inspections suit tenanted properties, prestige homes and security-conscious sellers, and they give the agent longer with each genuine buyer. Most good campaigns run both: scheduled Saturday opens plus midweek privates for the serious. One practical note: ask your agent for written feedback after every open, including the count of groups through and any contract requests. The pattern across the first three opens is your campaign’s vital signs.

The first-two-weeks rule

A new listing gets its biggest audience in its first two weeks, because every buyer with a saved search is notified the day it goes live. These are also your best buyers: the ones who’ve inspected twenty homes, missed out twice, and know exactly what your property is worth. If your price is right, they act fast.

Miss that window with an ambitious price and the listing starts to age in public. Buyers can see days on market and price cuts, and both read as weakness. The longer it sits, the more every enquiry begins with “what’s wrong with it?” and every offer arrives discounted accordingly.

> “ *Launch at the price you’d accept, not the price you’d love.*

The strategic consequence is blunt: **launch at the price you’d accept, not the price you’d love.** The fantasy number doesn’t function as a free option; it actively burns your best fortnight. If you and your agent disagree on price, resolve it before launch, not via a public reduction in week four. And if the first two weeks bring solid traffic but no offers, that’s not bad luck, it’s the market’s answer. Reprice decisively in week three rather than bleeding 1 per cent a month until spring.

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Offers, negotiation and exchange

An offer is a package, not a number. The seller who only reads the price is negotiating with one eye shut.

Reading an offer properly

Weigh every offer on four axes:

- **Price**, obviously, but only alongside the rest.
- **Conditions.** An unconditional offer at $840,000 can beat a conditional one at $855,000, because conditions are exit doors. Every condition is a probability discount on the headline number.
- **Deposit.** A 10 per cent deposit signals a committed, organised buyer. A 5 per cent deposit isn't disqualifying, but it tilts the read.
- **Settlement terms.** A settlement date that matches your onward purchase can be worth real money. So can a rent-back period if you need one. Terms are where flexible sellers harvest value that stubborn ones leave on the table.

Insist that every offer comes to you **in writing**, with all conditions stated. Verbal offers relayed by phone are negotiating instruments, not offers.

The common conditions, decoded

Subject to finance gives the buyer a stated period (commonly 14 to 21 days) to obtain formal loan approval, failing which they can withdraw with deposit refunded. It's the most common condition and the most common reason sales collapse, usually via a low bank valuation rather than the buyer's income. Sensible responses: prefer buyers with pre-approval, keep the finance period tight, and have your agent confirm the buyer's broker is real and progressing. **Subject to building and pest** gives the buyer an inspection window (commonly 7 to 14 days) and the right to withdraw, or in practice renegotiate, if the report turns up defects. This is where your Chapter 4 decision pays off: a seller who already knows their building's condition can hold the line against the ritual post-inspection discount request. **Subject to sale** of the buyer's own property is the weakest condition of all; if you accept one, demand a release clause letting you keep marketing and bump the buyer if a better offer lands.

Cooling-off periods: what your buyer can do after signing

In most states, a private-treaty buyer of residential property can withdraw within a statutory cooling-off period for a small penalty or none. No state gives cooling-off rights to buyers at auction. Sellers get no cooling-off anywhere (on the sale contract; NSW gives you one business day on the agency agreement, per Chapter 5).

STATE / TERRITORY	BUYER COOLING-OFF	PENALTY IF BUYER WITHDRAWS
NSW	5 business days (10 for off-the-plan)	0.25% of purchase price
Victoria	3 business days	$100 or 0.2%, whichever is greater
Queensland	5 business days	Up to 0.25%
South Australia	2 clear business days (runs from Form 1 service if later)	Deposit above $100 refunded
Western Australia	None (unless written into the contract)	n/a
Tasmania	None (unless written into the contract)	n/a
ACT	5 business days	0.25% of purchase price
Northern Territory	4 business days	None; deposit refunded in full

Cooling-off can generally be waived or shortened: in NSW a buyer's solicitor signs a section 66W certificate, and similar waivers exist elsewhere. Victoria's cooling-off also doesn't apply within three clear business days either side of a publicly advertised auction. Treat the table as the default position, and confirm current rules for your state when you sign, since these settings do get amended.

Gazumping, both directions

In NSW and the ACT, a sale isn't binding until contracts are formally exchanged, which can be days or weeks after a price is agreed. In that gap, a seller can legally accept a higher offer (gazumping the first buyer), and a buyer can equally walk away or reduce their offer (sometimes called gazundering). As a seller you're allowed to keep entertaining offers until exchange, and your agent is generally obliged to pass new offers on. If you want a deal locked fast, push for quick exchange, even by signing with a cooling-off period rather than waiting for the buyer's solicitor to finish a leisurely review. In Queensland and most other states, contracts are typically signed at the point of agreement, so the gap barely exists.

Negotiation tactics used on vendors

You'll hear plenty about tactics agents use on buyers. Less advertised is the toolkit used on you, the vendor, usually to close a deal that's 95 per cent done:

- **"The buyer is at their absolute limit."** Sometimes true. Verifiable never. Buyers tell agents their limit is below their limit; agents pass it along with conviction.
- **Anchoring with the lowball.** A weak written offer arrives early to reset your expectations, making the next offer look generous. Judge each offer against your evidence-based range from Chapter 2, not against the last offer.
- **Manufactured deadlines.** "They're bidding on another place Saturday." Maybe. Ask which one. The pause that follows is informative.
- **Feedback conditioning.** A steady drip of underwhelming "market feedback" softening you up for a price cut or a marginal offer. The cure is the data you agreed at launch: groups through, repeat visits, contract requests. If the numbers say the campaign is healthy, the feedback chorus deserves scepticism.
- **The split-the-difference reflex.** "You're at $865,000, they're at $845,000, let's do $855,000" feels fair and costs you $10,000 in one sentence. Counter at $862,000 instead; meeting in the middle is a habit, not a law.

$10,000

WHAT ONE SPLIT-THE-DIFFERENCE SENTENCE CAN COST YOU

Your standing defences: set your genuine floor (in writing, to yourself) before the campaign starts, require all offers in writing, and remember the agent's incentive arithmetic. On a 2.5 per cent commission, the agent's share of a $10,000 price improvement is $250, but a collapsed deal costs them everything. Agents are structurally biased toward "done" over "best". A good one resists the bias. The agreement you signed in Chapter 5 was your bet on which kind you hired.

> *Agents are structurally biased toward "done" over "best".*

09

Legals and settlement

Every state runs its own rulebook for selling property. Here's what you must prepare, who should prepare it, and what actually happens on settlement day.

Contract and disclosure, state by state

NSW. You cannot legally market a residential property until a contract of sale exists. Your conveyancer or solicitor prepares it before listing, attaching prescribed documents: title search, the zoning (section 10.7 planning) certificate, a sewer diagram, and any relevant strata or swimming pool compliance documents. Budget one to two weeks to assemble. Agents can't advertise without it, so this is genuinely step one.

Victoria. The vendor must give buyers a **Section 32 statement** (named for section 32 of the Sale of Land Act 1962) before they sign the contract. It discloses title and mortgage details, covenants and easements, zoning, rates and outgoings, building permits issued in the past seven years, owner-builder warranty matters, services connected, and notices affecting the land. A defective Section 32 can give the buyer the right to walk away even after signing, so this is no place for a DIY template. Have it professionally prepared alongside the contract before marketing begins.

Queensland. The big recent change. Under the Property Law Act 2023, from **1 August 2025** sellers must give every buyer a **Form 2 seller disclosure statement**, plus prescribed certificates (title search, registered plan, and where applicable body corporate certificate, pool safety certificate and notices), **before the buyer signs the contract**. The statement covers title, encumbrances, zoning, rates and water, environmental and heritage notices, tree orders and more. Get it wrong, or skip it, and the buyer may be able to terminate any time up to settlement. The disclosure pack is now effectively part of listing preparation in Queensland: engage your solicitor or conveyancer before the campaign starts, not after a buyer appears.

South Australia. Buyers must receive a **Form 1** (the vendor's statement under section 7 of the Land and Business (Sale and Conveyancing) Act 1994) disclosing title particulars, encumbrances, charges and a long schedule of government interests in the property. It's prepared by the agent or, more safely, a conveyancer, and must be served on the buyer; the buyer's cooling-off rights run from its service, and errors can extend the buyer's right to cool off. In practice the Form 1 gets assembled during the campaign and served at or before contract signing.

Western Australia. Sales run on a contract for sale by offer and acceptance, with the standard-form **Joint Form of General Conditions** (published jointly by the Law Society of WA and REIWA) doing the heavy lifting on terms. WA has no general vendor disclosure statement, though specific duties exist (strata disclosure, and the general prohibition on misleading a buyer). The agent typically prepares the offer and acceptance; a settlement agent or solicitor handles conveyancing from contract to settlement.

ACT. Like NSW, the contract must exist before marketing, and the ACT goes further: the pre-listing pack for a house must include a building inspection report, pest report, compliance report and an energy efficiency rating (EER), with the EER star rating disclosed in all advertising. Buyers can rely on these seller-provided reports, and budget accordingly: the pack commonly costs $1,000 to $2,000 before you've taken a photo.

Tasmania and NT. No comprehensive vendor disclosure statement; contracts are prepared by your solicitor or conveyancer at or before offer stage, with general law and consumer protections doing the disclosure work. Tasmanian practice typically has the seller's solicitor prepare the contract before or during the campaign.

Conveyancer or solicitor?

A licensed conveyancer handles standard property transfers, typically for $800 to $1,500, and for a routine freehold sale is all most sellers need. A property solicitor costs more ($1,200 to $2,500 for a standard sale) but can advise beyond the transfer itself. Choose the solicitor when anything is non-standard: deceased estates, family law settlements, sales involving trusts or SMSFs, boundary or easement disputes, off-the-plan, or a buyer who starts threatening things. One quirk: in Queensland, conveyancing is done by solicitors (standalone conveyancer licensing doesn't exist there), while in WA, settlement agents are the local equivalent of conveyancers. Whoever you choose, engage them **before listing**. In NSW, Victoria, Queensland and the ACT you legally need documents prepared before or at marketing; everywhere else, early engagement is the difference between a 24-hour contract turnaround and losing a keen buyer over a slow draft.

Settlement: the 30-to-90-day quiet stretch

Settlement is the date the money moves and the title transfers, negotiated in the contract. Common defaults: around 30 days in Queensland, 42 days (six weeks) in NSW and Victoria, with 30 to 90 days the practical range nationally. Longer settlements are a legitimate negotiating chip if you need time to secure your next home.

> **42 days**
>
> THE DEFAULT SETTLEMENT PERIOD IN NSW AND VICTORIA

Between exchange and settlement, your side's job list is short but strict: your conveyancer responds to requisitions and prepares the transfer, your lender gets the discharge of mortgage moving (start this immediately; lenders routinely take two to three weeks), and you keep the property insured until settlement and in the same condition as at sale. The buyer is entitled to a **pre-settlement inspection**, usually in the final week, to confirm exactly that, including that any contractually included items (dishwasher, curtains, the shed contents you promised) are present and working.

On settlement day, almost everything happens electronically through PEXA or a similar platform, attended by the conveyancers and lenders rather than you. In sequence: the buyer's funds are drawn, your mortgage is paid out and discharged, rates and water are adjusted between the parties to the day, transfer documents are lodged, and the balance lands in your nominated account, usually that afternoon. The agent, on written authority, releases the keys to the buyer and deducts their commission and any unpaid marketing from the deposit they've been holding in trust, remitting the remainder to you. Then it's done: no signing ceremony, no handshake, typically just a phone call from your conveyancer and a settlement statement by email. Keep that statement and the contract with your tax records, permanently if the property was ever income-producing.

> **WATCH FOR**
>
> Settlement delays caused by your own lender's discharge paperwork. It is the most common self-inflicted delay in Australian conveyancing, and in some states the party who can't settle on time pays penalty interest. Lodge the discharge authority with your bank the week you exchange, then have your conveyancer chase it weekly.

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Your 12-week selling timeline

Print this page. The weeks count down to exchange, with settlement following four to six weeks later. Adjust for your state's paperwork lead times.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO	DONE
Week 12	Research your suburb: pull six months of comparable sold prices, days on market and current competition. Build your own price range (Chapter 2). Start decluttering, one room a week. Book a skip if you're honest with yourself.	☐
Week 11	Shortlist and interview three agents using the 10 questions (Chapter 5). Ask each for a written appraisal with comparables, a marketing plan with line-item costs, and their commission including GST. Phone their past vendors.	☐
Week 10	Appoint your agent; negotiate commission and the agreement term before signing. Engage your conveyancer or solicitor and start contract or disclosure preparation (mandatory before marketing in NSW, VIC, QLD and the ACT). Notify your lender you intend to sell and ask about discharge timing and any fixed-rate break costs.	☐
Week 9	Book trades for repairs and painting. Order a pre-sale building and pest report if you've decided to (Chapter 4); in the ACT, commission the mandatory report pack now. Fix every small broken thing.	☐
Week 8	Decide on styling: consultation, partial or full staging. Get two quotes. Finish decluttering and deep-clean. Tackle street appeal: garden, fence, letterbox, driveway.	☐
Week 7	Trades and styling complete. Book photography for the property's best light, plus floorplan and (if warranted) video. Confirm the contract or disclosure pack is ready. Agree the launch price and the advertised price strategy in writing.	☐

WHEN	WHAT TO DO	DONE
Week 6	Approve photos, floorplan and copy (check every fact yourself). Sign off the portal tier and total marketing spend. Listing goes live late in the week to catch the weekend's saved-search alerts. Signboard up.	☐
Week 5	First open homes. Demand written feedback after each: groups through, repeat visitors, contract or disclosure requests, price feedback. This fortnight is your biggest audience; treat every enquiry as a live one.	☐
Week 4	Second weekend of opens. Review the campaign data against launch expectations. Strong traffic, no offers? Hold briefly. Weak traffic? Reprice decisively now, not in week 2. Auction campaigns: review buyer interest with the agent and start thinking about reserve.	☐
Week 3	Offers arriving (or auction week approaching). Insist on written offers with all conditions. Assess each on price, conditions, deposit and settlement terms (Chapter 8). Keep your pre-set floor in front of you.	☐
Week 2	Negotiate and accept, or auction day: set the reserve from campaign evidence the same week. Contracts signed or exchanged. Buyer's cooling-off period runs (state table, Chapter 8). Deposit paid into the agent's trust account.	☐
Week 1	Buyer's conditions in play: finance approval and building and pest inspection. Respond to any renegotiation attempt with your own evidence, not panic. Lodge your mortgage discharge authority with your lender immediately.	☐
Settlement window (2 to 6 weeks later)	Conveyancer prepares the transfer; lender processes the discharge (chase weekly). Book removalists, redirect mail, arrange utility disconnections for settlement day, keep insurance current until settlement. Leave the property in contract condition with all included items in place.	☐
Settlement day	Buyer's pre-settlement inspection passes. Settlement completes electronically; mortgage paid out, balance lands in your account, agent releases keys and remits the deposit less commission. Keep the settlement statement with your tax records. Done.	☐

Twelve weeks is comfortable, not generous. Sellers in NSW, Victoria, Queensland and the ACT should guard the paperwork weeks especially: a contract or disclosure pack that isn't ready is the most common reason launch dates slip, and slipped launches miss the photography weather, the portal weekend, and occasionally the market.

12 weeks

COMFORTABLE, NOT GENEROUS: RESEARCH TO EXCHANGE

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Your Property Guide is plain-English property education for Australians. No listings, no lead-selling to agents, no breathless market commentary. Just clear explanations of how buying, selling and owning property actually works in this country, written to be useful rather than exciting.

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